

The ANCHOR in the Storm (Acts 27)



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Outline: The ANCHOR in the Storm

- **Analyze Your Attitude**
- **Nourish Your Body**
- **Call upon the Lord**
- **Hoist a Sail**
- **Obey Orders**
- **Remove Baggage**

Introduction: “Amazing Grace” is one of the most beloved of all hymns because it speaks to the need of every soul to experience the wonderful forgiveness of Almighty God. Another contributing factor to the hymn’s

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popularity is that it reminds us that salvation is not the absence of struggle. One should never confuse eternal life with earthly leisure. Before we enter our heavenly home to sing for ten thousand years, we will experience “many dangers, toils, and snares.”

Chapter 27 of Acts describes with tremendous detail one of the dangers that the apostle Paul encountered during his ministry. This account illustrates some key survival strategies for life’s storms. Scripture identifies several causes for storms. Some are caused by human error while others blow into our lives by divine design to shape our character to be more like Christ. Regardless of how a storm starts, how to survive is the burning question of those in the storm.

Ron Mehl described his storm as an unexpected “punch in the stomach.” In his insightful book, *Surprise Endings*, Dr. Mehl shares his testimony of being

diagnosed with cancer.

"Ron, the news isn't good. You have leukemia." He needn't explain. A pastor friend of mine had just died of the disease. It was like someone had just grabbed my life's book out of my hands, flipped through the pages, then handed it back to me. I found myself staring at the last chapter long before I'd ever wanted or expected to. Receiving that kind of news is like a punch in the stomach. It knocks the wind out of you. So many things flash through your mind. So much confusion. My wife was a strength and comfort to me when so many things seemed wrong. We turned to the Lord and to His Word. We were reminded that peace and rest don't come from understanding everything, but from trusting the Lord. ¹

We can survive the "storm punches" of life, and it helps to have an anchor to stabilize the ship. An interesting sidebar of chapter 27 is the information about nautical techniques used during the first century. One of the survival tactics was to drop anchor not to secure a position but to stabilize the ship. ²

Using the letters of the word **ANCHOR** as an outline, we can apply these survival strategies to our lives.

Analyze Your Attitude

Notice the contrast in the attitudes of the apostle Paul and the crew. In verses 10-12, the crew rejects the advice of Paul and listens to the owner of the ship whose only concern is to make a profit. Later in verses 20-22, the crew has lost all hope, and they listen to Paul's exhortation to take courage. This is an amazing turn of events. The reluctant sailor is now the confident comforter, and the arrogant sailors are now cowering in fear.

The transformation illustrates what can happen when our attitude is out of alignment. When we overestimate our ability, we operate in a realm of pride. Seasoned sailors knew they should not have attempted this journey during the storm season, but like a rebellious teenager trying to conquer the world by himself, these men set sail. The Bible says in Proverbs 16:9 that pride goes before the fall. Not only did the crew overestimate their ability, they underestimated the adversity.

The description of the storm indicates that it was a typhoon with hurricane strength. The storm was so violent that it drove the ship away from land. They lost all control. Darkness enveloped them with no sight of sun or moon for several days. Perhaps you have experienced a similar darkness, or you know someone who feels helpless, battered, and tossed around by the severity of their circumstances. Another aspect of the crew's attitude was their exaggeration of negative possibilities. They saw death as the only option. This attitude is what happens often in the case of divorce or suicide

when individuals choose a permanent solution to a temporary problem.

Charles Swindoll has wisely said that life is 10 percent what happens, and 90 percent is determined by our attitude in response to what happens. When facing storms, we must guard our attitudes by not overestimating our ability, underestimating adversity, or exaggerating the possibilities.

Nourish Your Body

A second survival strategy illustrated in the text is Paul's instruction in verse 34 to the crew: "Now I urge you to take some food" (NIV). While this is not the venue to provide a detailed plan for physical fitness and nutrition, we should learn from this account that neglecting physical nourishment during a crisis only adds to the problem. These men were fighting for their lives on the open seas. They needed their strength. To lose a life because of starvation or fatigue would be an unnecessary tragedy. Poor nutrition threatens our ability to respond effectively. Education research has revealed that students who eat a nutritious breakfast perform better in school. In Scripture, we see almighty God tending to the physical needs of Jonah and Elijah as they struggled with depression. The practice of many churches to provide food to grieving families illustrates the inseparable link of emotional and physical nourishment required to survive some of life's most difficult experiences.

Call upon the Lord

In verse 23, we learn of Paul's vision. I believe he received this late-night revelation during his prayer time as he was calling upon the Lord. Paul must have been a night owl because Acts 16 describes his midnight praise service that resulted in a miraculous earthquake. The text clearly references his personal faith when it says, "the God whose I am" (NIV). His faith was not based on this midnight vision; rather Paul believed and trusted that God was in control.

Imagine Paul standing on the deck in the storm's darkness praising his God. Every person should ask the penetrating question, "To whom do I belong?" Some belong to their job. Others belong to their golf club or professional organization, but Paul belonged to Almighty God. While affiliations with civic or professional groups offer certain privileges, none of their perks compare to the presence of God during a storm.

The Lord responded to the call of one His chosen servants by providing comfort and courage. Scripture reveals numerous titles given to God that express His response to calls for help. For example, Psalm 18 identifies God as my Strength, my Rock, my Fortress, my Deliverance, my Shield, My

Stronghold, my Support, and my Savior.

Hoist a Sail

Verse 40 mentions another interesting survival technique. God used the phrase, "hoisted the sail," to encourage me during a very difficult time in my life. It was as if God said to me, "Son, you must continue pressing forward. Don't wallow in misery. Fix your eyes on Jesus, and head for the light at the end of the tunnel." Hoisting a sail means that we will strive for progress regardless of the situation.

The Bible assures us that God works in all things to accomplish His will and good pleasure in our lives (Rom. 8:28; Phil. 1:6). God does not cause all the storms of life, but He can use the storm winds to blow perseverance, humility, courage, and faith into our lives. A hoisted sail pictures our willingness to catch the divine breeze that guides and shapes our character.

Obey Orders

At the beginning of the journey, the crew considered Paul an insignificant prisoner. They ignored his prophetic warning to stay in Fair Havens, but now Paul rises to a position of influence and leadership. Warren Wiersbe states, "A crisis does not make a person; a crisis shows what a person is made of, and it tends to bring true leadership to the fore."³ To survive storms, we must follow orders. Sometimes our orders come from other believers who have been through a similar crisis. Their experience provides encouragement and insight. The passengers learned that Paul was not just an imprisoned preacher. According to 2 Corinthians 11:25, he had survived previous shipwrecks.

Sometimes our orders come straight from Scripture: "Be strong and courageous." "Call upon the Lord in the day of trouble." "Consider it all joy when you encounter trials." "Wait upon the Lord to renew your strength." Whether we receive our instructions through personal Bible study or from the wise counsel of an experienced friend, we must learn to obey orders. Paul told the passengers, "Stay with the ship." I am convinced that God provides marching orders for His children who battle life's storms, but we need humble hearts and open ears to hear His voice.

Remove Baggage

The final lesson of our "Anchor Strategy" is to remove the unnecessary baggage (vv.18-19; 38). The crew set out to make money, which is a worthy goal, but now the higher purpose of survival consumed their attention. Storms cause us to evaluate what are the most important things in our lives. Throwing the cargo overboard is a vivid reminder that the most important

things in life are not things. The loving respect of family and friends outweighs any material blessing. The crew ask the question, "What good is expensive cargo to us if we are dead?" Jesus said in Mark 8:36 that there is no profit for a man to gain the whole world if he loses his soul in the process.

Parents often refuse to unload cargo and spend time with their children until a storm hits. Then they realize that one more gift will not reach their rebellious teenager. A cancer diagnosis reveals the futility of a new car to bring lasting joy. When a tornado destroys your dream house, you recognize that a home consists of more than building materials. Hebrews 12:1-2 describes our life as a race, and the passage exhorts us to throw off sin and everything that hinders us from running effectively. Our lives are too hindered by sin, too cluttered with stuff, and too busy with unnecessary activity. The storm described in Acts 27 helped define priorities. Our storms will do the same.

Conclusion: When the great missionary David Livingstone returned to Scotland after sixteen years of service in Africa, his body was emaciated from numerous diseases. A near-fatal lion attack had disabled his left arm. Livingstone's endurance and courage are legendary. While he was speaking to a group at Glasgow University, a student asked what sustained him during the most difficult times. Livingstone said, "It was Christ's promise that He was with me to the end. This is the word of a gentleman of the most strict and sacred honor, so there is an end." The storm will eventually pass. Until that time, Christ, who is the Anchor of our soul, has promised to stay the course with you